

promised to live an angelic life is obvious. For the Christian, just as he is commanded to do, pushes himself to fulfill the Master's commandments as much as possible, and this is what is proper to the angelic orders: to always fulfill and perfect the divine commands.

So, then, in this way, those who have been baptized and keep the divine commandments are not far from the manner of life [*politeia*] of the angels, inasmuch as they take care to preserve in their body the purity of the bodiless powers, as the Apostle cries out: "Our citizenship [*politeuma*] is in heaven" (Phil. 3:20). And the divine Chrysostom says: "Let us then draw to us the invincible aid of the Spirit, keeping the commandments, and we will by no means be inferior to the angels."¹⁵⁶ And again he says: "The baptized and saved Christian receives a double grace. First, in that he is given life by the grace of the Holy Spirit; and, second, in that he becomes like a light bird, and flies freely to the heavens, living with the angels."¹⁵⁷

OBJECTION 6

Some apply to divine Communion this saying from Proverbs: "If thou hast found honey, eat so much as is sufficient for thee, lest thou be filled therewith, and vomit it" (Pr. 25:16).

¹⁵⁶ *On John* 75.5, PG 59, 409; NPNE (V1-14), 276.

¹⁵⁷ Translator's note: This quote is actually from Bishop Severianos of Gabala (*De Mundi Creatione* 4.2, PG 56, 459). See footnote 133 above.

To these sophistries we are ashamed even to reply. For when we speak about honey as food, it is not with reference to the divine Mysteries, but to the delights proceeding from noetic spiritual vision and perfection, according to Gregory of Sinai and other Fathers. But if they take "honey" to mean the divine Gifts, then I hear the same writer of the Proverbs saying to me: "My son, eat thou honey, because it is good; and the honeycomb, which is sweet to thy taste. Thus shalt thou perceive wisdom in thy soul. For if thou find it, thine end shall be good, and hope shall not fail thee" (Pr. 24:13-14).¹⁵⁸

In any case, they must explain to us what they understand by "sufficient," for we have no other way to measure the frequency of Communion except by the sacred Canons of the Apostles, and the whole Church of Christ. That is, to commune either four times a week (and if possible even every day), as Basil¹⁵⁹ and the divine Chrysostom¹⁶⁰ discuss, or at least every Saturday and Sunday and the other Feast Days, as when the Apostle commands married couples to abstain from one another on these days so that they may commune in the divine Mysteries, saying: "Defraud ye not one the other, except it be with consent for a time, that ye

¹⁵⁸ Translator's note: And St. Nikodemos interprets Proverbs 9:1-5 as a call to frequent Communion and as a clear prophecy of the Christian Sacrifice: "Wisdom hath builded her house, she hath hewn out her seven pillars. She hath slaughtered her sacrifices; she hath mingled her wine; she hath also furnished her table. She hath sent forth her servants, calling with a loud proclamation to the feast, saying.... Come, eat of my bread, and drink of the wine which I have mingled" (Pr. 9:1-5) (See *Heortodromion*, vol. 2, 130-137, and *Pedalion*, 5-6; *The Rudder*, 6).

¹⁵⁹ Cf. *Epistola* 93, PG 32, 484B; NPNE (V2-08), 179.

¹⁶⁰ Cf. *Adversus Iudeos* 3.4, PG 48, 867.

may give yourselves to fasting and prayer" (1 Cor. 7:5).¹⁶¹

As Timothy of Alexandria states: "They are to abstain from coming together on Saturday and Sunday, on account of the spiritual sacrifice which is offered to God on those

¹⁶¹ Translator's note: Interpreting this passage of St. Paul, St. Nikodemos writes:

The married couple is to especially abstain from marital relations when they intend to receive the divine Mysteries. Then, they must abstain for at least three days prior to receiving Communion. I say this concerning the times outside of the fast periods when they happen to commune, because during the days of fasting when they commune, they also [in addition to food] abstain from relations on account of the fast. (*Hermenia eis tas 14 Epistolais tou Apostolou Paulou* [Explanation of the Fourteen Epistles of the Apostle Paul], vol. 1 [Thessaloniki: Orthodoxos Kypsele, 1989], 461)

Also see St. Nikodemos' commentary on Canon 13 of the Sixth Ecumenical Council (*Pedalion*, 230; *The Rudder*, 306-307). And St. Symeon of Thessaloniki writes:

The fourteenth and fifteenth question ask similar things: whether an ordained man should know his wife the day he celebrates the Liturgy, and if he should know her after celebrating the Liturgy. Such things, my brother, are works of negligence and of bad judgment, for Paul says: "He who is engaged in ascetic struggle exercises self-control in all things" (1 Cor. 9:25). If they who were deemed worthy to see Mt. Sinai smoking and to hear the sound of the trumpet were given a command not to come near a woman for three days (cf. Ex. 19:15), and if the priest Ahimelech asked David if he had been with a woman the previous night when David asked to eat the bread of the Presence, and only when David confessed that he had not [been with a woman for three days] did Ahimelech dare give him that bread to eat, which was a type [of the Heavenly Bread] (cf. 1 Kg. [1 Sam.] 21:1-6), who, then, would dare be so bold as to approach the Altar after coming together with his wife? Especially if even on the night before the Sacrifice when, if one happens to have a nocturnal fantasy,

days."¹⁶² That is, on these days the Divine Liturgy is celebrated so that they may receive Communion.

And, concerning Feasts, the divine Gregory Palamas of Thessaloniki says:

One day of the week... is called the Lord's day (Sunday), because it is consecrated to the Lord, Who on that day arose from the dead, disclosing and giving prior assurance of the general resurrection, when every earthly activity will come to an end. And you must not engage in any worldly activity that is not essential; and you must allow those who are under your authority and those who live with you to rest, so that together you may all glorify Him Who redeemed us through His death and Who arose from the dead and resurrected our human nature with Himself. You should bring to mind the age to come and meditate upon all the commandments and statutes of the Lord, and you should examine yourself to see whether you have transgressed or overlooked any of them, and

one must be reverent and draw back, as we have been taught... Therefore, let those who are in sacred orders keep themselves pure prior to liturgizing, and also the day of the Liturgy, for they are sanctified by Communion, and God must not have communion with the flesh.... If someone must exercise self-control in order to see the glory of God and in order to pray, how much more necessary is it, then, that one exercise self-control when he intends on liturgizing and partaking of the most-dread Mysteries? (*Responsa ad Gabrielem Pentapolitanum*, Questions 14 and 15, PG 155, 864D-868A)

¹⁶² Canon 13 (*Pedalion*, 672; *The Rudder*, 897). [Translator's note: St. Nikodemos actually references here, by mistake, Canon 4 of Dionysios of Alexandria. Note, however, that Canon 3 of Dionysios of Alexandria (*Pedalion*, 549; *The Rudder*, 720) addresses the same subject, as does Canon 5 of Timothy of Alexandria (*Pedalion*, 668; *The Rudder*, 892).]

you should correct yourself in all ways. On this day you should go to the temple of God and attend the services held there, and with sincere faith and a clean conscience you should receive the holy body and blood of Christ. You should make a beginning of a more perfect life and renew and prepare yourself for the reception of the eternal blessings to come.... In this way you will sanctify the sabbath, observing it by doing no evil deeds. To the Lord's day you should join the days dedicated to the great feasts, doing the same things and abstaining from the same things.¹⁰⁸

OBJECTION 7

Some, on account of their fearlessness toward God, call frequent Communion a heresy. They say that, just as those who are baptized outside of the tradition of the Church are heretics, likewise are those people who commune frequently heretics.

We are bewildered by such audacious words and, in truth, do not know what to say. We say only this: that, according to such an opinion, it follows that all of the Saints are heretics, and not only those who encouraged the faithful to receive divine Communion, but also those who accepted their words. And so are all of the priests who daily celebrate

¹⁰⁸ *A New Testament Decalogue 4, GrPhilokalia*, 951-952; trans. *The Philokalia*, vol. 4, 326.

and partake of Communion (what blasphemy they say!), and indeed St. Apollo, who was greatly renowned for his holiness and had five thousand disciples in his care. The divine Jerome, who sought him out, writes concerning him:

After we had prayed, washed our feet, and stood at table, they treated us spiritually and bodily, that is, we partook of the divine Mysteries with them, as they do every day.

Then, after the meal, while we rested, they went out into the desert to pray on their knees until the morrow, until the time for service came. And after the ninth hour and vespers, they communed. After Communion, some sat and ate, while the more fervent went to practice stillness, living only by the strength of divine Communion. He of blessed memory told us many things profitable to the soul, primarily that we should commune in the divine Mysteries daily, and that we should receive strangers as if they were angels of God, as did Abraham, Lot, and others, for "upon these two commandments hang the whole Law and the Prophets" (Mt. 22:40).

Since, then, all the members of the choir of the divine Fathers are confessed as Saints and genuine servants of Christ, it follows that those who speak in opposition to them are also opposed to the Apostles, the Ecumenical and Local Holy Councils, and the Saints. And they are not only opposed to these, but also to the Lord Himself, Who says: "Whoso eateth My flesh, and drinketh My blood, hath eternal life" (Jn. 6:54). And again: "This do in remembrance of Me" (Lk. 22:19), that is, every day and always, according to the interpretation of the divine Chrysostom, as we said previously.

St. Timothy of Alexandria even allows demoniacs to receive Communion every Sunday, if they do not blaspheme

the divine Gifts: "If one of the faithful is possessed by a demon, but does not deny the Mystery or blaspheme it in any way, let him receive Communion. Not, however, every day, for it is sufficient for him to receive only on Sunday."¹⁶⁴

So, the divine Fathers allow not only those who are healthy, but also those who are demoniacs, to partake frequently of the divine Mysteries, while those blessed people who object to what we have said do not even allow those who are of a sound mind to commune, but rather seek to appear more lawful than the law.

OBJECTION 8

Some object saying: "Being human beings, are Christians not disturbed by gluttony, vainglory, laughter, idle talk, and other like passions? How, then, can they frequently commune?"

St. Anastasios of Antioch responds to these people saying: There are many people who, on account of their infrequent Communion, fall into sins. There are others who commune more frequently, and therefore greatly protect themselves from many evils, fearing the judgment of Holy Communion. Therefore, if we fall into some small, pardonable sins on account of our being human, either with our tongue, or our ears, or our eyes, and we fall as victims of deceit into vainglory, or sorrow, or anger,

¹⁶⁴ Canon 3 (*Pelalion*, 667; *The Rudder*, 891).

or some other like sin, let us condemn ourselves and confess to God. Thus let us partake of the Holy Mysteries, believing that the reception of the divine Mysteries is unto the remission of sins and purification. But if we also commit grave sins which are evil, carnal and impure, and we have rancor towards our brother, until we worthily repent of these sins, let us not boldly approach the divine Mysteries.

But because we are human beings, bearing flesh and weaknesses, and pollute ourselves with many sins, God has given us various sacrifices unto the remission of our sins. If we offer these sacrifices to Him, they purify us in order that we may approach the Mysteries. Merciful almsgiving is a sacrifice which cleanses man from sins. There is also another sacrifice which is unto salvation and the remission of sins, concerning which the Prophet David says, "A sacrifice unto God is a broken spirit; a heart that is broken and humbled God will not despise" (Ps. 50:17).

If we offer these sacrifices to God, and if we have some faults on account of being human, we will be able to approach Holy Communion with fear, trembling, and compunction, just as the woman with the issue of blood drew near to Christ, weeping and trembling.¹⁶⁵ There is sin which is unto death, there is sin which calls for the repentance we have described, and there is sin which requires bandaging [with a penance]. However, true repentance is able to heal all things. The person who approaches to partake of the Mysteries with fear, trembling,

¹⁶⁵ Cf. Mk. 5:25–34; Lk. 8:43–48.

confession, and compunction receives forgiveness, while the person who communes without fear and with disdain receives punishment. Those who receive Communion disdainfully and unworthily not only do not receive forgiveness for their sins, but also are leapt at even more by the devil. But when Christians receive Communion with fear, not only are they sanctified, and do they receive forgiveness for their sins, but also is the devil driven far away from them.¹⁶⁵

Even with all of these indisputable testimonies of the holy teachers of the Church, some still do not cease to dissent, but continue to raise objections.

¹⁶⁶ Cf. *Questions* 7, PG 89, 385C-389D. [Translator's note: Commenting on the words of the Divine Liturgy: "The Holy Things for the holy," St. Nicholas Cabasilas also says:

Those whom the priest calls holy are not only those who have attained perfection, but those also who are striving for it without having yet obtained it. Nothing prevents them from being sanctified by partaking of the Holy Mysteries, and from this point of view being saints... The faithful are called saints because of the Holy Thing of which they partake, because of Him Whose body and blood they receive. Members of His body, flesh of His flesh and bone of His bone, as long as we remain united to Him and preserve our connection with Him, we live by holiness, drawing to ourselves, through the Holy Mysteries, the sanctity which comes from that Head and that Heart. But if we should cut ourselves off, if we should separate ourselves from the unity of this most holy body, we partake of the Holy Mysteries in vain, for life cannot flow into dead and amputated limbs. And what can cut off the members from this holy body? "It is your sins which have separated Me from you" (1s. 59:2), says God. Does all sin then bring death to man? No indeed, but mortal sin only; that is why it is called mortal. For according to St. John there are sins which are not mortal (cf. 1 Jn. 5:16-17). That is why Christians, if they have

OBJECTION 9

"At that time, the majority of Christians received Communion, while the minority did not. It is for this reason that the divine Fathers placed the minority under the rule of a Canon, so that the majority might not be scandalized. Today, however, since the majority of Christians do not receive Communion, barring a few, neither should these few commune, so that there may not be disorder in the Church and so that the majority may not be scandalized."

The people who say these things should, before contending that they are so, first know what exactly scandal and disorder mean. Scandal is that which distances a man from God and brings him near to the devil, according to Basil the Great: "Committing sin alienates us from the Lord and associates us with the devil."¹⁶⁷ And again he says: "Everything opposed to the will of the Lord is a scandal."¹⁶⁸ To say it more clearly, a scandal is any stumbling block placed in the road in order to trip up the person walking on it. The Prophet asks God to deliver him from these: "Keep me, O Lord, from the hand of the sinner; rescue me from unjust men who have devised to undermine my steps. The proud (or the demons)

not committed such sins as would cut them off from Christ and bring death, are in no way prevented, when partaking of the Holy Mysteries, from receiving sanctification, not in name alone, but in fact, since they continue to be living members united to the Head. (*Sacrae Liturgiae Interpretatio* 36, PG 150, 448D-449B; trans. *A Commentary on the Divine Liturgy*, 88-89)]

¹⁶⁷ *Moralia* 22.1, PG 31, 741B; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 103.

¹⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 33.2, PG 31, 752A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 111.

have hid a snare for me, and with cords have they spread a snare for my feet; stumbling blocks (scandals) near the paths have they set for me" (Ps. 139:4-5).

Seeing as the minority in this same way scandalized the majority at that time, drawing them into negligence and transgression of the commandment of God, and now the majority scandalizes the minority, thus pulling them into violation of the commandment, what should be done? Just as at that time the minority cut off their own wills and followed the majority in doing the will of God, so now the majority must cut off their wills and follow the minority in doing the will of God. The opposite should not happen; namely, the minority should not forsake the command of God just because they are few, and follow the majority into transgression of the commandment. For if this is how matters ought to proceed, the Prophet Elias, the Apostles, and so many other Fathers—as many, that is, as struggled on behalf of the truth—should have hid the truth and followed the majority, for they were in the minority. For this reason Basil the Great says: "Regarding the things which are according to the will of the Lord, even though some may be scandalized, one must demonstrate courageous boldness."¹⁶⁹

But if some say that they are unable to see others communing frequently without being scandalized, let them understand for themselves that this is the result of either envy or hatred of their brother.

So, we cannot disdain the commandments of God in order that men not be scandalized, as Chrysostom says:

Only up to this point should we think about not scandalizing

¹⁶⁹ Ibid., 33:5, PG 31, 753B; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 113.

men: that we do not give and afford them a handle against us. But if, though we give no such opportunity to them, they choose to criticize us thoughtlessly and without discrimination, let us laugh and weep because of their foolishness. Try to do "good things in the sight of the Lord and in the sight of men" (2 Cor. 8:21). If, though you do good things, he still derides, have no more concern over it.... And Christ spoke thus about those who are scandalized: "Let them alone: they be blind leaders of the blind" (Mt. 15:14).... For if the scandal is caused by us, then woe unto us; but, if it is not caused by us, it is not so. And again: Woe unto you through whom "the name of God is blasphemed" (Rom. 2:24). What then? If I do something that is good, but another blasphemes, that is nothing to me, but (a sin) only to him. For through him was God blasphemed.... When that which is pleasing to God is hindered by another's being scandalized, we should be concerned about this: that we not be forced because of him to offend God.

Tell me, if, while we are discouraging and putting drunkards to shame, someone is scandalized, should I stop speaking?... It is always good to know the right mean. Many reviled because a certain beautiful virgin remained as she was (and did not marry, but became a nun), and they criticized those who catechized her (the priests who made her a nun). What then? Was it their duty to desist for that (and not tensure her a nun)? By no means. For, on the contrary, they were doing nothing wrong, but rather, a very virtuous deed pleasing to God.... On all occasions it behooves us to follow the laws of God, to take great pains that we give no occasion for scandal,

so that we may be innocent and be deemed worthy of enjoying God's philanthropy.¹⁷⁰

So much concerning scandal. Concerning disorder, this is when something occurs out of order. Since, as we said earlier, it is the order and law of the Church for those Christians who are present at the Divine Liturgy to receive Communion (that is, as many as are not prohibited because they are under a rule), it follows then that as many as do not receive Communion are clearly causing disorder, transgressing the laws of the Church. On this account the Prophet Habakkuk says: "The sun was exalted, and the moon stood still in her course (order)" (Hab. 3:11). That is to say, the Sun of Righteousness,¹⁷¹ Christ our God, was raised onto the Cross; and the moon, that is, the Church, stayed in her course and in order; which means that the Church held fast to the will and command of God, from which she had fallen.¹⁷² Therefore, those who do what is outside of the commandment of God are the ones who cause scandals and disorder, and not those who struggle as much as they can to keep the Master's commandments.

¹⁷⁰ *On Acts* 46:3, PG 60, 324-325; NPNF (VI-11), 281-282.

¹⁷¹ Mal. 4:2.

¹⁷² Translator's note: For a more detailed commentary on this passage of the Fourth Ode (Hab. 3:2-19), see St. Nikodemos' work, *Kepos Chantion* [*Garden of Graces*], which interprets the Nine Odes ([Thessaloniki: Regopoulos, 1992], 112-114).

OBJECTION 10

Still others bring up the *Tome of Union* and say that there is a Canon written in the *Horologion*¹⁷³ which designates that Christians should receive Communion three times a year.

Regarding this Canon these blessed people bring forth, even though it is a fabrication and false addition—or even if it be correct—I ask them, please, to tell me: is it just and right that this Canon should have more authority than the so great a number of trumpets of the Holy Spirit that have been cited thus far? The imperial laws write that any law written by an emperor that is found to be contrary to the sacred Canons and divine Fathers is rendered void. The divine Chrysostom says that a custom or habit contrary to the divine laws is to be terminated. Again he says: "Habit is a difficult thing, and it is hard to break and hard to avoid.... Therefore, the more you understand the power of a habit, the more should you endeavor to be rid of a bad habit and change yourself over to a good one."¹⁷⁴

How, then, do they seek to support their soul-destroying habit? Since they seek to hide the truth with this Canon, we will briefly show its true meaning, so that the truth may be clearly revealed and no one deceived any longer.

The Canon came about for the following reason: Leo the Wise, because he married for a fourth time, was

¹⁷³ Translator's note: The *Horologion* or *Book of the Hours* is the service book of the Orthodox Church used in the daily cycle of services.

¹⁷⁴ *Ad Illuminandos Catechizes* 1.5, PG 49, 230; St. John Chrysostom: *Baptismal Instructions* (New York: Paulist Press, ACW, 1963), 145.

excommunicated by the then-Patriarch Nicholas. The emperor deposed Nicholas from the throne because the patriarch did not want to allow him a fourth marriage, and put on the throne in his stead Euthymios, who then loosed the Emperor from his excommunication. Owing to these events, the hierarchs and the people were divided into two factions, some siding with Patriarch Nicholas, and others with Euthymios.

After Emperor Leo died, his brother Alexander reigned in his stead, and he deposed Euthymios from the patriarchal throne and restored it to Nicholas. When Alexander too died, his nephew, Constantine Porphyrogenetos, the son of Leo the Wise, reigned. His father-in-law, Romanos, had the title of *Basilepator* (father of the emperor). Constantine and Romanos convened a Council in the year 922 A.D. This Council not only prohibited fourth marriages, but also drew up the following Canon against third marriages, which says:

Regarding anyone who is forty years old, and is not ashamed of his age or does not heed the modest life required of Christians, but is provoked to marry for a third time only because of the desires of the flesh, we decree that he is not to partake of Holy Communion for five years. This is to be observed in all strictness, and no one has permission to lessen the years of excommunication. After the five years have passed and he is deemed worthy to commune, he is not allowed to approach Communion at any other time except during the saving Resurrection of Christ our God, purifying himself beforehand as much as possible by the fast of Holy Lent. But whoever is thirty years old and has children from his previous marriage, and then wishes to take a third wife, is not allowed to

partake of Holy Communion for four years. After the four years pass and he is permitted to partake of the Mysteries, he is allowed to receive only three times a year: during the Feasts of the saving Resurrection of Christ our God, the Dormition of our immaculate Lady the Theotokos, and the Birth of Christ, for there is a fast preceding each of these Feasts, and from fasting one receives benefit and cleansing.¹⁷⁵

This Act of the Council was named the *Tome of Union* because it united the hierarchs and the rest of the people who had been divided on account of the fourth marriage of Leo.

I do not know what blessed person, either on account of illiteracy or out of desire to block Christians from eternal life, maimed this Canon and placed it in its mutilated condition into the *Horologion*. And then, our blessed Spiritual Fathers, finding it, spread it throughout the world, placing the penance of a third marriage upon all Christians, whether married for a second time, or just once, or virgin, and upon those of all ages.

I am not amazed so much by the Spiritual Fathers, but by the good hierarchs and shepherds who did not immediately sound the horn with the God-inspired trumpets of truth, in order to castigate the evil sower of that weed and uproot from the Church that dead plant. For they have the authority by the grace of the Holy Spirit to sustain that which is good and to correct whatever is in need of correction.

Perhaps the hierarchs make the excuse that, since they are under the yoke of the Ottomans and caught up in many

¹⁷⁵ In the Acts of the Council, vol. 2, 975.

concerns, they entrust these things to the teachers and preachers. These blessed hierarchs, one not wanting to lose his quietude, and another making other excuses — all of them together abdicate their responsibility and throw the burden one upon the other. So they bury the word of God and the truth as if in a tomb. And by their silence they show that they acquiesce to all the things which are happening, as the divine Meletios the Confessor says:

*"He who possesses knowledge of the truth,
And, in whatever way, deliberately hides it,
Not openly preaching it or speaking it with boldness,
And does not uphold the divine and august Canons,
Or the laus presided over by the Fathers,
Is justly punished no less than the transgressors of these.
He who is silent about the truth hides Christ in a tomb,
As one Father has said, and another, again, says.
He who is silent about the faith is in grave danger
Of eternal punishment and of the pit of perdition.
It is not just, lawful, or right for the faithful to be silent
When the laus of God are being violated,
And the evil seek to support their deception.
When someone is in danger of being separated from God,
Said one of the great Fathers,
And when evils are attributed to God,
What faithful Christian can be silent? Who can be at peace?
For silence means consent and betrayal,
As was clearly shown by the Lord's Forerunner
And the brave Maccabees together with him,
Who, on account of the smallest commandment, were in danger
unto death,*

*And did not even betray the smallest part of the Law.
War is many times known to be praiseworthy,
And battle appears better than soul-destroying peace.
For it is better to stand against those who do not believe correctly,
Than it is to follow them and be of one mind with them,
Thus being united with them and separated from God."¹⁷⁶
And the divine Chrysostom says, "If it is not good for a man to be silent when he is wronged, how will one who remains silent and indifferent when the divine laws are insulted not be worthy of punishment?"¹⁷⁷*

OBJECTION 11

Many object and say that for someone to receive Communion is not a dogma of the faith, which must be kept obligatorily.

Even if frequent Communion is not a dogma of the faith, it is nevertheless found to be a commandment of the Master included in His other sayings, especially when He says: "This do in remembrance of Me" (Lk. 22:19). That is, "Do this frequently and every day, as long as the present age lasts." And for this reason, being that it is a commandment of the Master, it must necessarily be kept as we said previously, in the first part of this book.

As many as raise this objection show by this that they

¹⁷⁶ *Alphabetaalphabetos*, Hypothesis 10 (Thessaloniki: 1923).

¹⁷⁷ *De Sancta Babyla, Contra Iulianum et Gentiles* 9, PG 50, 547.

want to strip the dogmas, leaving them bereft of every ecclesiastical formulation and legislation. We, however, ask them, how then can dogmas be supported? Did not the divine Chrysostom previously tell us that our Christian manner of life requires correct dogmas, and that dogmas require a pure life? And that a pure manner of life is born of and attained through the divine commandments, the sacred laws of the Church, and the venerable traditions and formulations of the divine Fathers? If, then, we violate the divine Canons, the Master's commandments, and the rest, our pure manner of life will be destroyed. When a pure manner of life is destroyed, we also lose correct dogmas, and will be left barren and without light.

There is not sufficient time to enumerate the thousands of Saints who suffered and died for the ecclesiastical laws and Canons. There are, on the other hand, some who are so audacious that they not only do not suffer for the truth, but also actually oppose the truth. And they boldly refute the Master's commands by prohibiting from divine Communion those who approach, for no reason at all and without them having committed any offense. This is something very bold, for not even did our Lord turn away Judas from Communion, though He knew that he was an abominable vessel of wickedness. Christ daily receives all who would partake of Communion. The worthy He purifies, illumines, and sanctifies. The unworthy He first turns over to their convicting conscience, and then, if they amend their ways, receives them with compassion. If they remain uncorrected, He gives them over to various illnesses, as the Apostle says, for since many in his time were receiving Communion unworthily, they were becoming ill on this account, and many were

dying.¹⁷⁸

Those blessed people who raise this objection prohibit the Orthodox from divine Communion without even knowing the spiritual condition of the communicants, and only to sustain their bad habit and evil custom, which has prevailed unto the detriment of their souls.

But let us ask Basil the Great to speak to us the truth:

Question 11: Whether it is right or safe to refuse to obey any of the commands of God, or to impede the one who has been commanded to do them, or to be tolerant of those who are doing the impeding, especially if the person impeding is genuine and close to God, or if some seemingly plausible reason impede the accomplishment of the command.

Reply: Considering the Lord's words: "Learn of Me, for I am meek and lowly in heart" (Mt. 11:29), it is clear that we are more solidly instructed in all things when we recall the words of our Lord Jesus Christ Himself, the Only-begotten Son of the living God. Therefore: When John the Baptist said to Him, "I have need to be baptized of Thee, and comest Thou to me?" (Mt. 3:14), He replied, "Suffer it to be so now, for so it becometh us to fulfill all righteousness" (Mt. 3:15). Again, in the presence of the disciples, when Peter decried the sufferings which the Lord prophesied He must undergo in Jerusalem, He said with great displeasure, "Get thee behind Me, Satan, thou art a scandal unto Me; for thou savourest not the things that be of God, but those that be of men" (Mt. 16:23). On another occasion, when Peter, moved

¹⁷⁸ Cf. 1 Cor. 11:30.

by reverence toward his Master, refused His ministration, the Lord again said, "If I wash thee not, thou hast no part with Me" (Jn. 13:8).

And if the soul requires further assistance from examples taken from persons like ourselves, let us recall the words of the Apostle: "What mean ye to weep and to break mine heart? For I am ready not to be bound only, but also to die at Jerusalem for the Name of the Lord Jesus" (Acts 21:13). Who could be more admirable than John? Or more sincere than Peter? Or what motives could have been more reverential than those which they alleged? I know, furthermore, that neither Moses, that holy man, nor the Prophet Jonah remained blameless before God when they entertained thoughts that were contrary to obedience. By these examples we are taught neither to contradict, nor to impede, nor to tolerate those who impede others.

And if the word of the Scripture teaches beyond a doubt that we dare not perform these particular actions or others like them, how much greater is our obligation to imitate the Saints with regard to the rest when they say, "We ought to obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29) and, "Whether it be right in the sight of God to hearken unto you more than unto God, judge ye. For we cannot but speak the things which we have seen and heard" (Acts 4:19-20).¹⁷⁹

And again Basil says,

No one must impede the person who is doing the will

¹⁷⁹ *De Baptismo* 2, Question 11, PG 31, 1621B-1624A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 425-426.

of God, whether he does it because of a commandment of God, or for some other reason related to a commandment; nor ought the doer of the will of God to permit any to hinder him, even though they be genuine friends of God, but he should remain steadfast in his decision.... The person who does a commandment of God without sincerity, and yet maintains in appearance the exactness of the Lord's teaching, should not be impeded, because no one is harmed insofar as the act itself is concerned, and sometimes certain people may be benefited by it; yet such a person should be exhorted to have a disposition worthy of his good action.¹⁸⁰

And: "We should not follow human traditions to the extent of violating the commandment of God.... No one may prefer his own will to the will of the Lord, but in everything we must seek and do the will of God."¹⁸¹

The divine Chrysostom says:

We must bravely stand against whatever prevents us from that good desire. Listen to what Christ says: "He that loveth father or mother more than Me is not worthy of Me" (Mt. 10:37). For whenever we do something that is according to the will of God, we must consider whatever prevents us as our enemy and opponent, whether father, or mother, or anyone else.¹⁸²

Ignatios the Godbearer says: "Every one that teaches anything besides what is commanded, even if he is credible,

¹⁸⁰ *Moralia* 19.1 and 2 PG 31, 733A and 736A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 97, 99.

¹⁸¹ *Ibid.*, 12.2 and 4, PG 31, 724A and 724D; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 89, 90.

¹⁸² *De Virginitate* 78.5, SC 125, 374.

even if he fasts, even if he lives celibately, even if he works miracles, even if he prophesies, let him be in your sight as a wolf in sheep's clothing, laboring for the destruction of the sheep."¹⁸³

And the divine Meletios the Confessor says:

"Do not listen to monks or to presbyters,

When they wrongly counsel you and lead you astray.

What — only monks? And only presbyters?

Do not even listen to bishops when they advise you

To do and to say and to believe that which harms the soul."

OBJECTION 12

Some are scandalized because what they say, especially concerning the prohibition from frequent Communion, does not convince us, and they hold up the following things in their defense: First, that the Canons and commandments are under the authority of the hierarchs. Second, that we are not to examine what hierarchs, teachers, and Spiritual Fathers tell us, but only to obey simply everything they say. And third, they put forth the Apostolic saying: "Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves" (Heb. 13:17).

To this three-part objection we personally have nothing to say, so that we may not cause some of the people to be upset and disturbed. To say nothing to these things, however,

¹⁸³ *To Heron the Deacon of Antioch 2*, PG 5, 912A-912B; ANF (01), 113.

we think would be harmful to the soul. Wherefore, let us see what the Saints say, so that no one can complain.

Basil the Great responds to the first part of the objection saying:

For if the Lord Himself, in Whom the Father was well pleased, "in Whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:3), Who having received all authority and all judgment from the Father says, "He gave Me a commandment, what I should say, and what I should speak" (Jn. 12:49); and again, "Whatsoever I speak therefore, even as the Father said unto Me, so I speak" (Jn. 12:50); and the Holy Spirit speaks not from Himself, but whatever things He hears from Him, those He speaks¹⁸⁴ — how much more is it both pious and safe for us to think and do this (that is, not to transgress the divine commandments, but to be willingly obedient to them)?¹⁸⁵

The divine Chrysostom shows from the very ordination of hierarchs that the hierarchs are subject to the divine Canons and commandments, saying:

Since the high priest (of the Old Law) was the head of the people, he himself (being the head) was also to be under an authority, for an authority not subject to a higher authority is unbearable; so, by his having the sign of authority over his head, it was indicated that he was under a law. It is ordered (by the Law) that the head be not bare, but covered, in order to teach the head of the people that he too has a head (an authority) over him.

¹⁸⁴ Cf. Jn. 16:13.

¹⁸⁵ *De Fide* PG 31, 677A-677B; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 57-58.

This is why during the ordination of a priest in the Church the Gospel of Christ is placed upon his head, so that he may learn that he is receiving the true tiara (authority) of the Gospel. (Here the word "priest" takes the place of "hierarch," being used according to the general sense of the priesthood, for, to quote Dionysios the Areopagite, only hierarchs wear "the words handed down by God" upon their heads.)¹⁸⁶ It is also so that he may learn that, even though he is head of all, he is nevertheless under the laws (of the Gospel); and that, while he has authority over all the other laws, he himself is under the authority of the laws; and also that, while he enacts all other laws, he himself is governed by the law. For this reason, one of the brave ancients (the Hieromartyr Ignatios), who was illustrious in the priesthood and in martyrdom, wrote to a certain priest (that is, a hierarch, Polycarp) saying: "Let nothing be done without your consent; neither should you do anything without the approval of God."¹⁸⁷ So, the fact that the hierarch has the Gospel on his head is a sign that he is under its authority.¹⁸⁸

Regarding the second part of the objection, that we should not examine what hierarchs, teachers, and Spiritual Fathers tell us, but be obedient in all things, Basil the Great responds to it saying:

He who is in charge of preaching the word (that is,

¹⁸⁶ Cf. *De Ecclesiastica Hierarchia* 5.2 and 5.3.1 and 7, PG 3, 509B, 509C and 513C; *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 239-240, 242..

¹⁸⁷ *To Polycarp* 4, SC 10, 174; ANF (01), 94.

¹⁸⁸ *De Legatione* 4, PG 56, 464.

whether he is a teacher or a hierarch) must do and say everything with great deliberation and judgment, aiming at pleasing God, inasmuch as he must be tested and borne witness to by the very people who are entrusted to him.¹⁸⁹

Again he says: "The hearers that have been instructed in the Scriptures should test what their teachers say. Those things that are in agreement with the Scriptures they should accept, but should reject that which disagrees; and they should reject even more those who persist in such teachings."¹⁹⁰ Next he says: "Those who have little knowledge of the Scriptures should be able to recognize those who are holy and Saints by the fruits of the Spirit they exhibit. And they should receive the people who display these as Saints, but reject those that do not."¹⁹¹ Elsewhere he writes: "One must not be easily carried away by those who feign the truth, without examining them, but one must investigate each man with the help of the test given by Scripture."¹⁹² And once more: "Every word or thing should be confirmed by the testimony of the divinely inspired Scripture, so those who are good may be assured, and so that those who are bad may be ashamed."¹⁹³

The divine Chrysostom responds to the third part of the objection, saying:

Anarchy is an evil, and the occasion of many calamities,

¹⁸⁹ *Morales* 70.37, PG 31, 844D-845A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 184.

¹⁹⁰ *Ibid.* 72.1, PG 31, 845D-848A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 185-186.

¹⁹¹ *Ibid.* 72.2, PG 31, 848B; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 186.

¹⁹² *Ibid.* 28.1, PG 31, 748A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 108.

¹⁹³ *Ibid.* 26.1, PG 31, 744C; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 106.

and the source of disorder and confusion.... But no less an evil also is the disobedience to rulers.... But perhaps someone will say that there is also a third evil, when the ruler is bad. I myself also know this, and no small evil it is, but a far worse evil even than anarchy. For it is better to be led by no one than to be led by one who is evil. For the former indeed are oftentimes saved and oftentimes in peril, but the latter will be altogether in peril, being led into the pit of destruction. How then does Paul say: 'Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves' (Heb. 13:17)?

Having said above, "Whose faith follow, considering the end of their behavior" (Heb. 10:7), he then says, "Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves." "What then," you say, "when he is evil, should we obey?" Evil? In what sense? If indeed in regard to faith, flee and avoid him; not only if he is a man, but even if he is an angel come down from heaven. But if in regard to life, do not be over-curious.... For hear Christ saying: "The Scribes and the Pharisees sit on Moses' seat" (Mt. 23:2). Having previously spoken many fearful things concerning them, He then says: "They sit on Moses' seat: all therefore whatsoever they tell you observe, do; but do not ye after their works" (Mt. 23:2-3). They have, He means, the dignity of office, but are of unclean life. Attend, however, not to their life, but to their words.

For as regards their characters, no one would be harmed thereby. How is this? Both because their characters are manifest to all, and also because though he were ten thousand times as wicked, he will never teach what is wicked. But as respects faith, the evil is not manifest to

all, and the wicked ruler will not shrink from teaching it. Moreover, "Judge not that ye be not judged" (Mt. 7:1) concerns life, [though] not faith.

Paul, however, has previously commended the shepherds (namely, has borne witness to the fact that they are sound in all things), and after this he says "Obey them that have the rule over you."¹⁹⁴

And elsewhere St. John again says: "But so and so," someone says, 'is a good man and a priest and lives a life of temperance and piety.' Do not speak to me of that good, temperate, pious priest! Let it be, if you wish, Peter or Paul or even an angel who has come down from heaven. Not even in such cases do I regard the dignity of persons. I do not recognize the law of any servant, but only the King's law. When we read what the King has written, let His servant, however high his office, be silent....

Why do you bring up the case of this man or that man? God will not acquit you because of the negligence of your fellow servants, but He will judge you according to the precept of His laws. "I commanded," He will say to you on the day of judgment, "you should have obeyed My command and not used this man and that man as an excuse, and concerned yourself with the evils of others." Tell me, is it safe for us to sin because the great David committed a grievous sin? This is all the more reason why we must be on our guard and emulate only the good works of the Saints. If we find negligence or transgression of the law anywhere, we must flee from it with great zeal.

¹⁹⁴ *On Hebrews* 34.1, PG 63, 231-232; NPNF (VI-14), 518-519.

Our account is rendered not to our fellow servants but to the Master, and to him shall we give account for all we have done in our lives.¹⁹⁵

So this is what the Saints say. But we, my brothers, since the Lord has called us in peace,¹⁹⁶ must obey the hierarchs, the Spiritual Fathers, and the teachers, on account of the dignity of the office which they have received from God. But if one of these is doing something irrational or prohibits us from doing some virtuous work, let us not cease from asking and beseeching him until we convince him and until the will of God is done, so that peace may reign among us; so that harmony and concord may prevail; so that there may be love between the Shepherds and the sheep, between the hierarchs and the Christian people, between the priests and the laity, and between the leaders and the led; and so that scandals, disturbances, schisms, and divisions be absent and far from us. For these things are what will destroy our souls, our homes, our churches, and every community and race. In brief, let us do all these things so that we may all be one body and one spirit, all with one hope, just as we were called,¹⁹⁷ so that the God of peace may also be with us.

¹⁹⁵ *Ad Illuminandos Catecheses* 1.5, PG 49, 229–230; *St. John Chrysostom:*

Baptismal Instructions, 144.

¹⁹⁶ Cf. Col. 3:15.

¹⁹⁷ Cf. Eph. 4:4.

OBJECTION 13

Some say: "Behold, we keep the commandment of the Lord and receive Communion two or three times a year, and this suffices as our apology."

To such people we reply that this too is good and beneficial. But for someone to receive Commune more frequently is much better. The more one approaches light, the more he is illumined; the more he approaches fire, the more he is warmed; and the more he draws near to holiness, the more is he made holy. Wherefore, the more frequently someone approaches God through Communion, the more is he illumined, warmed, and made holy. My brother, if you are worthy to receive Communion two or three times a year, you are also worthy, just as the divine Chrysostom says, to receive more frequently, performing the same preparation. What prohibits us from communing? Our negligence and our sloth. Being conquered by these, we do not prepare ourselves according to our abilities.

We also reply in another way. Such people do not practice the commandment of God as they think. For where did God (or any of the Saints) command that we should receive Communion two or three times a year? This idea is not to be found anywhere. We must therefore know that, when we practice a commandment, we must be careful to practice it according to the commandment. What I mean is that we must heed the place, time, purpose, manner, and all the circumstances under which we practice the commandment. This way the good will be perfect in everything and well-

pleasing to God.¹⁹⁸

The same applies to divine Communion. For someone to commune frequently is necessary, profitable to the soul, according to the commandment of God, perfectly good, and virtuous. But for someone to receive Communion only three times a year is neither according to a commandment nor perfectly good, for that which is not done in a good way is not good.

For this reason, just as the rest of the commandments of God demand to be performed at the time proper to each, according to the Ecclesiast: "There is a time for everything" (Ec. 3:17), so also does the commandment of divine Communion. We must afford the proper time to its performance, which is the moment when the priest cries out, "With the fear of God, with faith, and with love, draw near." Is this heard only three times a year? Alas and woe! And since the physical body needs to eat two or three times a day to live, does the poor soul then, in order to live the

¹⁹⁸ Translator's note: See St. Basil the Great's reply to the question, "Whether the work enjoined by the commandment is acceptable to God if the manner of performing it is not in conformity with the commandment of God" (*De Baptismo* 2, Question 8, PG 31, 1600A–1612A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 407 ff). And St. Maximos the Confessor says: "In everything that we do God searches out our purpose to see whether we do it for Him or for some other motive" (*Second Century on Love* 36, *GrPhilokalia*, 304; *The Philokalia*, vol. 2, 71). Elsewhere, the divine Maximos says: "The demons do not hate self-restraint, fasting, almsgiving, hospitality, the singing of psalms... or any of the other things which characterize a life lived according to God, so long as the aim and purpose of a person trying to live such a life are tilted in their direction" (*Fifth Century on Various Texts of Theology* 70, *GrPhilokalia*, 402; *Third Century of Various Texts, The Philokalia*, vol. 2, 227–228).

spiritual life, only need to eat its life-giving food three times a year, or even just once a year? Is not this a great absurdity? Otherwise, I fear—I fear that perhaps we do not profit from doing the commandments. For we adulterate them and corrupt them, and we are not doers of the law, but creators of anti-laws. While fasting on many occasions and thinking that we were fulfilling the commandment of God, we were actually sinning, as the divine Chrysostom says:

Do not tell me that they are fasting; but show me that it is God's will that they fast. If it is not God's will, then their fasting is more unlawful than any drunkenness. For we must not only look at what they do, but also seek out the reason that they do it. What is done in accordance with God's will, even if it seems bad, is the best of all things. What is done contrary to God's will, even if it seems very good, is the worst and most unlawful of all things.... For it is God's will, and not the nature of things, that makes the same actions good or bad.¹⁹⁹

¹⁹⁹ *Adversus Iudaeos* 4.1, PG 48, 873.